# FAQs – Telecom Billing Chatbot Knowledge Base

Oct 11, 2026 · @ST

## About this document

This FAQ is the general-knowledge layer for the ICMS billing chatbot of **ConnectWave Telecom** (a placeholder name; find-and-replace with your brand). Answers are modeled on publicly documented practices of large US carriers such as Verizon, AT&T and T-Mobile as of October 2026; adjust every amount to your own tariff before go-live.

- **General answers** come from this document.
- **Account-specific answers** (balance, due date, plan on file, usage) must come from the ICMS API, never from this text.
- Placeholders in `{{double braces}}` are values the bot should fill from ICMS at answer time.

## Account & billing

**Q: When is my bill generated and when is it due?** Your bill is generated once a month on your bill-cycle date ({{bill_cycle_date}}). Payment is due about 21–25 days later, on {{due_date}}. The bill covers *next* month's plan charges in advance and *last* month's usage, add-ons and one-time charges in arrears.

**Q: Why is my first bill higher than my monthly plan price?** First bills usually include partial-month (prorated) charges from your activation date to your first bill-cycle date, plus one month of service in advance, plus one-time activation fees. From the second bill onward the amount settles to your normal monthly price.

**Q: What is proration?** When you start, stop or change a plan mid-cycle, you are charged (or credited) only for the days the service was active. Example: a $60 plan added 10 days before your cycle closes shows about $20 for those days.

**Q: Why did my bill change this month?** Common reasons: a plan or feature change (prorated), a promotion or discount ending, a new or upgraded device installment, international or overage usage, a one-time fee (activation, upgrade, late fee) or a change in

taxes and surcharges. The bot should pull `bill_comparison` from ICMS to show the line-item difference.

**Q: How do I read my bill?** A typical bill has: (1) account summary and total due, (2) monthly plan charges per line, (3) device installments, (4) add-ons and usage, (5) one-time charges and credits, (6) surcharges, government fees and taxes.

**Q: Can I change my bill-cycle date?** Yes, usually once every 6–12 months. Changing it creates one prorated transition bill.

**Q: How do I get a paper bill or switch to paperless?** Paperless billing is the default and is free; paper bills may carry a small monthly fee (commonly $1–$2) in some markets.

**Q: How do I dispute a charge?** Contact support within 180 days of the bill date. While a disputed amount is under review, you still pay the undisputed portion. Approved disputes appear as a credit on the next bill.

## Payments

**Q: How can I pay my bill?** Online account or app, autopay, phone (automated line is free; agent-assisted payment may carry a fee of about $10), in store, by mail, or through authorized payment locations. Accepted methods: bank account (ACH), debit card, credit card and digital wallets.

**Q: What is autopay and is there a discount?** Autopay charges your saved payment method on or a few days before the due date. Many carriers give $5–$10 per line per month off when autopay uses a bank account or debit card (often not credit cards) together with paperless billing.

**Q: What happens if I pay late?** A late fee is charged after the due date. Large US carriers charge about 5% of the unpaid balance or $10, whichever is greater (example). Continued non-payment can lead to service suspension, a reconnection fee (about $20 per line), and eventually cancellation and collections.

**Q: Can I get more time to pay?** Yes. Set up a payment arrangement ("promise to pay") before the due date through self-service. It keeps service active but usually does not waive the late fee.

**Q: Can a late fee be waived?** Support agents may waive a first-time late fee for accounts in good standing. The bot should not promise a waiver; it should hand off to an agent.

**Q: I paid but my account still shows a balance.** Card and wallet payments post within minutes; bank (ACH) payments can take 1–3 business days. If more than 3 business days have passed, contact support with your payment confirmation number.

**Q: How do I get a refund of a credit balance or deposit?** Credit balances roll to the next bill. After cancellation, remaining credits and security deposits are refunded to the original payment method or by check, typically within 30–60 days.

## Plans & changes

**Q: What plans do you offer?** Postpaid unlimited plans in three tiers, prepaid plans, connected-device plans (tablet, watch, hotspot) and home internet. See the *Product & Service Catalog / Rate Guide* for current prices.

**Q: Can I change my plan? When does it take effect?** Yes, any time. You choose to apply the change immediately (prorated on the next bill) or at the start of the next bill cycle (no proration). Moving off a promotional plan can end promo discounts permanently, so the bot should warn the customer before confirming.

**Q: How do I add or remove a line?** Add lines online, in store or by phone; a one-time activation fee (about $35–$40 per line) applies. Removing a line takes effect at the end of the cycle or immediately with a prorated credit. Any device balance on that line becomes due.

**Q: Why does my plan price drop with more lines?** Per-line prices are tiered: the more lines on one account, the lower the price per line.

**Q: What are the taxes and fees on my bill?** Two kinds:

- **Government taxes and fees** — sales tax, 911 fees, Federal Universal Service Fund. Set by authorities; vary by address.
- **Company surcharges** — for example an Administrative and Telco Recovery Charge (about $3.50 per voice line at Verizon, source) and a Regulatory Charge. Set by the company, not by the government.

**Q: What discounts are available?** Autopay + paperless, multi-line, and verified-group discounts (military/veterans, first responders, nurses, teachers, students, 55+). Low-income customers may qualify for a federal Lifeline benefit.

**Q: Can I keep my phone number?** Yes. Porting in requires your old account number and a port-out PIN from the previous carrier. Porting out is free; keep your account open until the port completes.

## Devices, returns & cancellation

**Q: Can I return my phone?** Yes, within 30 days of purchase (online orders: 30 days from ship date). A $50 restocking fee applies to wireless devices; accessories have no restocking fee. Full rules are in *Return & Exchange Policy Guidelines*.

**Q: How do device installments work?** The device price is split into 24 or 36 interest-free monthly payments on your bill. Promotional credits are applied monthly over the same period and stop if you pay off early, switch or cancel.

**Q: Can I upgrade before my device is paid off?** Yes, but the remaining device balance becomes due unless an upgrade program or promotion covers it. An upgrade fee (about $35–$40) may apply.

**Q: Why is my phone locked?** Postpaid devices are unlocked automatically after 60 days on an active line in good standing; prepaid devices typically after 60 days of paid service.

**Q: How do I cancel service?** Call or visit a store; online cancellation is available in some markets. Service ends on the requested date. You pay any prorated charges to that date, all remaining device installments, and unreturned-equipment fees for leased home-internet equipment. Month-to-month plans have no early termination fee.

**Q: Will I get a final bill?** Yes, within one bill cycle after cancellation. Any credit is refunded within 30–60 days.

## Usage, travel & support

**Q: Is my data really unlimited?** Yes, with no overage charges. On lower tiers, data may be deprioritized during network congestion, and video may stream at standard definition. Premium tiers include a high-speed allowance before deprioritization.

**Q: How much hotspot data do I get?** It depends on the plan tier (see the Rate Guide). After the high-speed hotspot allowance, speeds drop to about 3 Mbps for the rest of the cycle.

**Q: Can I use my phone in Canada and Mexico?** Most postpaid plans include talk, text and data in Canada and Mexico at no extra cost, with a daily high-speed data cap.

**Q: What does international roaming cost?** Buy a day pass (about $12 per day, charged only on days you use the phone abroad) or a monthly international plan. Pay-as-you-go roaming is expensive; the bot should recommend a pass before travel.

**Q: How do I check my usage?** In the app or online account. The bot can fetch `usage_summary` from ICMS for the current cycle.

**Q: How do I contact support?** Chat (24/7), the app, phone, or a store. For billing disputes, fraud, number-port problems or account security, the bot must transfer to a human agent.

**Escalate to a human when:** the customer disputes a charge, asks for a fee waiver or credit, reports fraud or SIM-swap, requests cancellation, or asks a question this knowledge base does not answer.

## Sources

- Verizon return policy
- Verizon late fee guide (Gerald)
- Verizon admin charge increase (PhoneArena)